Kenneth J. Vella Jr.

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SUMMARY

Platform engineer working with Kubernetes since 2016, currently Lead Architect at The Wendy's Company. Building internal developer platforms, Kubernetes Operators, and delivery pipelines across GCP and AWS while mentoring engineers and setting shared technical direction. Background in application development, infrastructure provisioning, operations scaling, maintainability, and security.

- Lead platform teams: set priorities, mentor engineers, and align technical direction across teams
- Design and implement deployment and operations for cloud native applications on Kubernetes
- Migrate and refactor on-premises application stacks to the cloud for cost savings and scalability
- Implement Zero Trust for applications, workflows, and users to improve security posture
- Drive culture change through metrics, monitoring, and alerting to improve speed to market
- Enterprise application developer with a focus on JVM technologies integrated with a mainframe backend

SKILLS

Cloud	GCP, AWS, OCI
Kubernetes	GKE, EKS, OpenShift, kubeadm, etcd, Helm, Helmfile, ArgoCD, Argo Workflows, Kubebuilder, Controller Runtime, cert-manager, external-secrets, Longhorn, Harbor, kured, Reloader, Reflector, Node Feature Discovery, Headlamp, k8s-image-swapper
Languages	Go, Bash, Python, Kotlin, Java, JavaScript, SQL
Infrastructure	Terraform, Ansible, GitLab, Jenkins, Docker, HashiCorp Vault, Apache Kafka (Strimzi), NFS, Fedora CoreOS, Butane/Ignition, CRI-O, Podman, Renovate, Taskfile
Networking & Security	SSO (Keycloak, OAuth2 Proxy), CNI (Calico), Ingress (Traefik, Envoy, Kong, Nginx), Load Balancing (MetalLB), DNS (CoreDNS, NodeLocal DNSCache, Technitium, external-dns), VPN (WireGuard), Firewall (pfSense), Policy (OPA Gatekeeper, Kyverno)
Observability	OpenTelemetry, Grafana, Metrics (Prometheus, Mimir), Logs (Loki, FluentD, Splunk), Tracing (Tempo, Jaeger), Datadog, Grafana Alerting, Blackbox Exporter, Pushgateway
Data & Storage	PostgreSQL (CloudNativePG), SQLite, MariaDB, Neo4j, Elasticsearch, MSSQL, DB2, H2, Redis (Valkey), MQTT (VerneMQ), S3 (MinIO)
Development	Spring, Micronaut, Hibernate, Tomcat, Node.js, React, Next.js, Angular, Gradle, Maven
Testing	Testkube, K6, Ginkgo, JUnit, Mockito, Selenium

WORK EXPERIENCE

The Wendy's Company February 2022 to Present
Dublin, Ohio (Remote)

Lead Architect, Digital May 2025 to Present

- Set architecture direction for Wendy's Digital across cloud infrastructure, delivery pipelines, and Kubernetes runtime
- Partner with product and engineering teams to design scalable, secure cloud native solutions on GCP
- Define standards and reference architectures for application delivery, networking, and identity

Lead Engineer, Platform December 2024 to May 2025

- Led the platform engineering team delivering CI/CD pipelines, GKE clusters, and developer experience tooling
- Set priorities and roadmap for the platform team
- Facilitate Tech Radar exercises across teams to align direction on tools, platforms, and languages
- Mentor engineers on technical and career goals

Cloud Systems Engineer, Contractor via Galileo Insights February 2022 to December 2024

- Develop Helm charts and Kubernetes Operators to enhance developer experience
- Administer GitLab and automate runner provisioning on GKE via Terraform
- Establish developer SDLC with a focus on speed to market
- Manage GCP IAM by implementing RBAC and Workload Identity
- Design and build self-managed workflows for Docker and Terraform on Kubernetes
- Architect private cloud networking between applications, databases, and cloud services
- Promote and implement Chaos Engineering across all environments

- Run cloud native applications in production on ephemeral (100% spot instance) infrastructure

Galileo Insights February 2022 to December 2024
Royal Oak, Michigan (Remote)
Principal Platform Engineer

- Set direction for company product implementation in GCP
- Design and build GCP runtime platform and delivery pipeline
- Convert ClickOps management of Auth0 configuration to GitOps via Terraform

Quavo, Inc. February 2019 to December 2024
Wilmington, Delaware (Remote)
Cloud Systems Engineer, Consultant (Contract)

- Design and guide infrastructure team transition from VM-based deployments to Kubernetes
- Introduce Terraform for infrastructure within the AWS environment
- Provision and administer firewall / VPN solution for developer network on AWS
- Automate VPN client distribution for workstations via Microsoft Intune
- Implement SSO for AWS resources with an identity provider (Azure AD)

ArborMetrix, Inc. April 2020 to February 2022
Ann Arbor, Michigan (Remote)
Infrastructure Architect, Senior DevOps Engineer

- Run Kafka (Strimzi) on Kubernetes with client authorization (Keycloak)
- Build Kubernetes Operators to automate RBAC for team self-service
- Create application platform with service mesh (LinkerD) and distributed tracing (Jaeger)
- Configure shared OAuth2 Proxy middleware for client authentication / authorization via Traefik
- Build monitoring stack for logs (ELK) and metrics (Prometheus), visualized in Grafana
- Administer HashiCorp Vault including secret engines, authentication, audit logs, and backups
- Manage DNS hosted zones and TLS certificates for applications
- Maintain multiple EKS environments in Terraform on spot instances, including IRSA and version upgrades
- Establish company SDLC and a Git-first approach to infrastructure configuration

Auto-Owners Insurance Company December 2009 to April 2020
Delta Township, Michigan
Senior Software Developer

- Design, develop, load test, and maintain a customer-facing J2EE proposal application
- Break apart monolithic applications on VMs into microservices running on OpenShift v3
- Convert batch ETL processes into real-time streaming ETL with integrated telemetry
- Design and implement software delivery pipelines using CI/CD principles
- Create, manage, and version internal APIs consumed across lines of business
- Create educational tools and mentor peers to grow their technical careers

PROJECTS

Homelab Platform 2016 to Present

- Run a 9-node bare-metal kubeadm cluster on Fedora CoreOS, CRI-O, and Calico; GitOps (ArgoCD) for 86 Helm charts
- Write Go controllers (~11k lines): CloudNativePG pre-drain switchover, ArgoCD sync controller, cluster health dashboard
- Gate node reboots (kured) on workload health; automate etcd snapshots and control-plane certificate expiry alerts
- Self-host metrics, logs, and traces (Mimir, Loki, Tempo) via OpenTelemetry, plus an outage dead-man switch
- Run routing (pfSense, since 2009) with MetalLB BGP peering, DNS over DoH (Technitium), and VPN (WireGuard) via a VPS
- Localize packet loss hop by hop with Smokeping and MTR; NetAlertX device discovery from pfSense DHCP leases
- Host SSO (Keycloak, OAuth2 Proxy), secrets (External Secrets), PostgreSQL (CloudNativePG), Kafka (Strimzi), S3 (MinIO)

EDUCATION, CERTIFICATIONS & CONFERENCES

Michigan Technological University · B.S. in Computer Science · Upsilon Pi Epsilon (ΥΠΕ) Honor Society 2005 to 2009
Oracle Certified Associate, Java SE 7 Programmer December 2015
KubeCon + CloudNativeCon North America Annually, 2022 to 2026
UberConf (2018) · Central Ohio Software Symposium (2012, 2017) · ArchConf (2015)